



YOU ARE **23 WEEKS EXACTLY**
119 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

External appearances are deceptive: although your baby seems very well developed, it's still early in the pregnancy—the state of the cervix and progesterone produced by the placenta both play a part in ensuring that labor does not start for some months yet.

“You may be surprised by the strength of feeling you have for your baby, and this maternal instinct will grow stronger each day.”

Do you feel as though you're a mom yet? Whether or not you're a maternal person, you'll already have started, instinctively, the process of becoming a mother. You may be taking better care of yourself, eating healthier foods, and making lifestyle changes, not necessarily to benefit your own health but for your baby. You're likely to find yourself being very protective and nurturing toward your growing belly, wanting the best for your baby, and being worried about anything happening to them. It's nothing to worry about if you don't feel this bond: all women are different and it may not be until you're holding and caring for your baby that you experience strong maternal feelings.

The more you involve your partner in the pregnancy, the greater the chance of them developing a strong parental instinct. By reading books or on the internet about how the baby is developing at every stage, and attending some or all of the prenatal appointments with you, they will be able to picture the baby and follow his progress as closely as possible.

ASK A DOCTOR

I've got the flu. Will this harm my baby? A mild case of the flu won't harm your baby. The best thing to do to prevent rare but serious complications from the flu is to get your flu shot during pregnancy. If you have a mild symptoms, drink plenty of fluid to stay hydrated, and eat several small meals a day to maintain your energy levels. Ask the pharmacist's advice before taking any over-the-counter medication. Call your doctor if you don't improve after 24–48 hours, or your temperature exceeds 101°F (38°C). If you experience problems breathing, notify your doctor immediately.

CURIOUS TODDLERS

Your toddler will undoubtedly be curious about why you have suddenly got so fat! Keep things simple, along the lines of “Mommy is growing you a baby sister or brother, but they won't be here just yet.” Over the coming weeks, explain in more detail what having a new baby means.